**Aquifer Open Study Notes**

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# Joshua

## Joshua 1:1–2

Moses died on Mount Nebo, which is east of the Jordan River (Deuteronomy 34:1–5).

## Joshua 1:1–9

God confirmed Joshua as Israel's leader and the man to succeed Moses. God promised Abraham that those descended from him would possess the land of Canaan (Genesis 12:7; 15:7; 17:8). God repeated this promise to Moses (Exodus 3:6–8; 13:3–5; Deuteronomy 1:6–8; 6:10–19). Now, God was ready to fulfill this promise through Joshua.

Joshua led the army of Israel's first people who settled in the land God promised to give Israel. Joshua had victories against two Canaanite groups. First, he won battles in the south and then in the north. This allowed access to the hill country for settlement by the Israelites.

## Joshua 1:3

The death of Moses did not end God's presence with or guidance of Israel.

## Joshua 1:4

- The most southern region where ancient Israel settled was the Negev, near Beersheba (15:28). Israel's most northern tribes settled in parts of the Lebanon mountains, making them neighbors of the Sidonians.
- The Hittites were one of the subgroups that made up Canaan's population (see study note on 3:10).

## Joshua 1:5

God promised Joshua that he would never fail or abandon him, just as he had promised Moses (compare Deuteronomy 31:6–8).

## Joshua 1:6

You shall: God chose Joshua to lead and fulfill the promise he had given to their ancestors (see Exodus 6:8).

## Joshua 1:6–9

For emphasis, God told Joshua three times that he would need to be strong and courageous in order to be successful against the Canaanites. There were a lot more Canaanites than Israelites at the time.

The people also needed to obey all the instructions Moses had given them so they could:

- settle the land,
- establish farms with successful production, and
- build homes, villages, and cities.

The land belongs to God, as does the whole earth (Psalm 24:1). God brought Israel into Canaan as tenants, not as owners (Leviticus 25:23).

## Joshua 1:8

- This Book of the Law (Hebrew torah, meaning "instruction") probably refers to the book of Deuteronomy (see Deuteronomy 4:44; 29:21; 30:10; 31:9–12). It includes Israel's foundational law codes and God's moral and spiritual instruction.
- God commanded Joshua to think about and speak God's instruction day and night. This command means that Joshua was to focus on it continually (compare Deuteronomy 6:6–7; 17:18–20).

## Joshua 1:9

- As the Israelites entered Canaan, they prepared to fight the worshipers of the gods of the land of Canaan. They feared these gods might help the people who lived in Canaan to win. To encourage Joshua, God used his personal name, the LORD (Hebrew Yahweh; see study note on Exodus 3:15). This was to remind him that the LORD was more powerful than any false gods the Canaanites might ask to help them.
- your God is with you: God's constant presence enabled Joshua to follow God's instructions.

## Joshua 1:10

commanded: Joshua now began leading God's people.

## Joshua 1:11

Because of fear and lack of trust in God, the earlier generation refused to enter the promised land from the south 40 years earlier (see Numbers 13–14). Now, a new generation was ready to enter from the east, by crossing the Jordan River.

## Joshua 1:12–15

Reuben, Gad, and the half-tribe of Manasseh had requested and received from Moses the conquered land east of the Jordan (Numbers 32:33).

## Joshua 1:13

God wanted the people of Israel to experience the spiritual, cultural, and emotional rest of a right rela-

tionship with him and each other, not just the physical rest of living in a secure and abundant land (see Hebrews 4:1–11).

## Joshua 1:14

The warriors from the tribes of Reuben, Gad, and the half-tribe of Manasseh had promised to cross the Jordan River with the rest of Israel to help conquer the land (Numbers 32:16–19). Joshua reminded them of their duty.

## Joshua 1:17

Israel often did not obey Moses. However, the tribes living east of the Jordan River crossed with the rest of Israel. They did not return to their land and homes until Joshua dismissed them (22:6).

## Joshua 1:18

To disobey God's chosen ruler was to commit treason against God himself (that is, to act against God as king).

## Joshua 2:1

- Shittim was about 13 kilometers (8 miles) east of the Jordan River on the plains of Moab, across from Jericho (see Numbers 25:1).
- the house of a prostitute: In the house of a prostitute, strangers could avoid attention they did not want. According to tradition, Rahab was an innkeeper as well as a prostitute (Josephus, Antiquities 5.1.2). Other evidence from the ancient Near East suggests that women who owned and operated inns were often prostitutes.

## Joshua 2:1–24

- Like any good military commander, Joshua sent out spies or scouts to get information about his objective.
- Because Israel planned to approach Canaan from the east, they could not avoid Jericho.

## Joshua 2:2

The spies' speech probably made them recognizable as foreigners. Hebrew and the languages spoken in Canaan were closely related dialects within the same language family, but they differed in vocabulary and grammar.

## Joshua 2:3

Jericho's king assumed Rahab was both loyal to the city and unaware of the men's mission.

## Joshua 2:4–5

It is not necessary to either approve or condemn Rahab's lie to the king's messengers. She may not have known the ethical standards that God later gave to Israel. Another possibility is that saving a human life was a higher moral value than telling the truth in that situation.

## Joshua 2:6

The inner fibers of flax were processed to make linen. The first step involved laying out the flax stems to dry on the flat rooftop.

## Joshua 2:7

Medium-sized towns such as Jericho had one main gate made of two very large wooden doors reinforced with bronze. The gate was barred for the night and opened again in the morning.

The authorities took a sensible precaution by shutting the gate immediately after the pursuers left. If the spies had not left the city, as Rahab said, the authorities might still find them in Jericho during the night.

## Joshua 2:9–10

- Rahab began to declare her faith in the Lord.
- dried up the waters: God parted the waters of the Red Sea for Israel (Exodus 14:21–28).
- Israel defeated Sihon and Og (Numbers 21:21–35).
- devoted to destruction: See Leviticus 27:28–29; 1 Samuel 15:3.

## Joshua 2:11

Even though the people of Canaan experienced God's judgment, Rahab's statement of faith was genuine and shown by her help to the spies. Because of this, God included her among his people (Hebrews 11:31).

## Joshua 2:12–13

Rahab's request demonstrated her faith in Israel and Israel's God.

## Joshua 2:14

When Israel attacked Jericho, Joshua and the two spies kept their promise to save Rahab (6:22).

## Joshua 2:15

Because Rahab's house was built into the wall of the city, she could hide the men on the flat roof of her house (2:6). She let them escape through the window down the wall's outer side.

### Joshua 2:16

The hill country of central Canaan rises steeply just west of Jericho. The pursuers from Jericho expected the two spies to go east toward Israel's camp across the Jordan. When the pursuers stopped searching, the spies were able to cross the Jordan without trouble.

### Joshua 2:19

we will be innocent. But ... his blood will be on our heads: The spies used a standard formula to accept responsibility for any of Rahab's family remaining with her in her house, but not for those who did not.

### Joshua 2:23–24

The spies' report encouraged the Israelites and gave them new confidence.

### Joshua 3:1

Israel had camped at Shittim since before Balaam spoke his messages from God (Numbers 22–24).

### Joshua 3:3

the ark of the covenant: The ark represented God's presence among the Israelites and symbolized his throne. When Israel traveled, a group of priests carried the ark in front of the people (Exodus 25:13–15; Numbers 10:33–36).

### Joshua 3:4

keep a distance of about two thousand cubits between yourselves and the ark: God did this so they would not become careless about his presence. They were to respond to God with deep respect and awe, because God is holy.

### Joshua 3:5

Consecrate yourselves: They had to separate themselves from anything ceremonially unclean that would prevent an Israelite from being able to enter God's presence (see Exodus 19:9–20; Leviticus 11:44).

### Joshua 3:7

To reassure the people that he had not brought them this far to abandon them, God made Joshua a great leader like Moses.

### Joshua 3:8

As they crossed the Jordan River, the ark led the way until the feet of the priests entered the water. The priests were to stand in the Jordan River, not on dry land. By carrying the ark into the water first, the obedient priests demonstrated their faith (compare James 2:18).

### Joshua 3:10

- This is how you will know: The adults who left Egypt with Moses had died. The people now entering Canaan with Joshua replaced them. The coming events would show God's presence and his promise to them.
- In Canaan, the Israelites would live among neighbors who worshiped false gods. So Israel might feel tempted to worship their gods and goddesses. None of these false gods deserved worship. By contrast, the Lord is the living God, and he was present among the Israelites.
- The Canaanites and Amorites were distinct peoples, but their names sometimes indicated all the pre-Israelite peoples of Canaan. The Hittites were related to the earlier Hittite Empire of Asia Minor that controlled much of Canaan. The Jebusites were from the city-state of Jerusalem, which Israel did not conquer fully until David's time. Little is known about the other three groups.

### Joshua 3:11

The ark of the covenant led the Israelites, showing them that the Lord of all the earth guided them into Canaan. Their God was not a local god limited to one place.

### Joshua 3:12

Joshua told the people to choose 12 men but did not reveal what this group of men would be doing (4:2–8).

### Joshua 3:13

Even though the Jordan River was flooded in the spring, the water stopped suddenly. This was a clear miracle.

### Joshua 3:15

The Jordan was overflowing its banks as a result of the spring runoff of the winter's rainfall and snowfall, especially from Mount Hermon.

### Joshua 3:16

Two amazing events happened. First, the water ... backed up as far upstream as Adam. This was about 40 kilometers (25 miles) away. Second, the whole bed of the river dried up as the remaining water flowed to the Salt Sea.

## Joshua 3:17

The repetition of the phrase on dry ground emphasizes that God performed a miracle.

## Joshua 4:2

Choose twelve men: These men represented Jacob's 12 sons. The tribe of Levi was not counted because the Levites settled in designated cities among the other tribes (Genesis 49:5–7; Numbers 1:49–52; 18:20). However, the number of tribes remained at 12 because Joseph's two sons (Ephraim and Manasseh) were accounted as separate tribes (Genesis 48:5).

## Joshua 4:5

to take a stone upon his shoulder: This implies that each man chose stones weighing about 100 pounds.

## Joshua 4:6

Joshua told the Israelites two times to get ready to explain to future generations. The stone memorial would help teach them (4:21).

## Joshua 4:9

- A second memorial of twelve stones in the middle of the Jordan River became covered with water when the river resumed its flow. The top of the monument would be visible during the dry summer seasons.
- are there to this day: This shows that the memorials stood for generations, until the final editing of the book (see Joshua Book Introduction, "Author and Date").

## Joshua 4:14

After God brought the Israelites safely across the Jordan River, the people recognized that God was with Joshua as their leader. They honored Joshua just as they had honored Moses. This trust in Joshua would be important in the years ahead.

## Joshua 4:18

After Israel crossed the river, the Jordan overflowed its banks as before. These events could not occur without God's intervention.

## Joshua 4:19–20

- The tenth day of the first month: This happened a few days before the Passover feast.
- Gilgal became an important worship center for early Israel. Although its exact location is uncertain, it was somewhere just east or northeast of Jericho. Its name means "wheel of a cart" (compare Isaiah 28:28). This suggests that Joshua set up the 12 stones in a circle (see study note on Joshua 5:9).

## Joshua 4:24

In addition to future generations of Israelites, all the nations of the earth were to understand God's power. At least some individuals in every group respond to the God who cares for them (Revelation 7:9–10).

## Joshua 5:1

- After hearing that Israel crossed the Jordan River, all of southern Canaan was in a state of alert, expecting an invasion.
- The Canaanites became completely terrified by Israel's amazing crossing of the Jordan River. They realized they were going to encounter a people whose God was more powerful than any false gods they worshiped.

## Joshua 5:2

- Before the Israelites turned their attention to Jericho, God directed Joshua to perform the covenant renewal ceremony of circumcising all the males born in the forty years since the exodus from Egypt. Because the land was part of the covenant promise, Israel's men needed to demonstrate their personal participation in the covenant through circumcision in order to enter into the land.
- Flint occurs in nature without human shaping. For this reason, people used flint knives for circumcision as a symbol of purity and holiness.

## Joshua 5:3

The name Gibeath-haaraloth means "hill of foreskins." This suggests the circumcision ceremony happened on a hill near Israel's camp at Gilgal.

## Joshua 5:4–7

This unexpected change in the story reminds us of Israel's earlier refusal to believe that God would safely bring them into Canaan (Numbers 14). This summary of God's judgment against their ancestors was a reminder to the current generation. They still needed to trust God in order to occupy the land their ancestors lost. Additionally, it marked the end of God's judgment on the previous generation.

## Joshua 5:8

until they were healed: Recovery from circumcision, which was a minor surgery, usually takes about three days if there are no complications.

## Joshua 5:9

Gilgal sounds like the Hebrew word galal, which means "to roll." At this place, God removed the shame of Egypt from his people.

## Joshua 5:10

- The Israelites killed the Passover lamb on the evening of the fourteenth day of the first month. Just as the Passover in Egypt marked the exodus from slavery, the celebration of this Passover in Canaan marked the attainment of the goal God had been leading the Israelites toward. This Passover also anticipated God's promised rest for his people in their new land.
- This was apparently the first Passover feast Israel celebrated since camping at Mount Sinai (Numbers 9:1–5). For the younger Israelites, it was their first Passover feast ever. For the older ones, it was their first since childhood.

Celebrating Passover after such a long break increased both the joy and the serious nature of the occasion. This was especially true because it was before the campaign to capture the land God promised to give the Israelites.

## Joshua 5:11

Israel again celebrated the Feast of Unleavened Bread, which lasts seven days after Passover (Leviticus 23:6). During this time, the people ate unleavened bread and roasted grain, a common food at harvest time (see Ruth 2:14).

## Joshua 5:11–12

God stopped providing manna each day because food from the land was now available (Exodus 16:31; Numbers 11:9).

## Joshua 5:12

Israel harvested the crops that the people of Jericho did not have time to harvest before Israel crossed the Jordan.

## Joshua 5:13

Joshua was scouting the land and the city's defenses near the town of Jericho to follow up on the report of the two spies (2:23–24). Joshua showed personal courage when he went toward the unknown man, who was holding a sword in his hand.

## Joshua 5:13–15

The commander of the LORD's army gave Joshua instructions for the attack of Jericho (6:2–5). Like God's earlier message to Joshua, this meeting intended to encourage Joshua before confronting the enemy (1:1–9).

## Joshua 5:14

- When Joshua realized who was standing before him, he fell facedown in reverence. This action showed that Joshua was ready to serve God fully and without reservation.
- Scholars disagree about who this commander was. Some think he was an appearance of God, others think he was Christ before becoming human, and others think he was an angel. The commander called himself the leader of the Lord's army, which may suggest that he was an angel. However, he did not stop Joshua from worshiping him, as angels usually do (for example, Revelation 22:8–9; compare Acts 10:25–26).

## Joshua 5:15

Take off your sandals, for the place ... is holy: This was what God told Moses at the burning bush (Exodus 3:5). Joshua clearly recognized the connection. This encounter assured him of God's blessing on Israel's first action against Canaan.

## Joshua 6:1

Jericho protected two key routes into the center of the hill country. If the Israelites did not capture the city first, a strong enemy would remain behind them, separating the Israelite forces from their families camped at Gilgal. They needed to capture Jericho first.

## Joshua 6:2

God's comforting words, "I have delivered Jericho into your hand," must have encouraged Joshua. All Joshua had to do was obey God, and he had a lifetime of practice at that.

## Joshua 6:4

- Seven is a biblical number representing perfection.
- Seven priests led the ark of the covenant, the symbol of God's presence, at the front of Israel's forces. This arrangement showed that God himself fought against the town. Israel only needed to march and watch, then shout and watch. Finally, they would easily capture the town after God did the work.
- The ram's horn (Hebrew shofar) could produce different pitches to signal either battle or worship. In

battle, the shofar warned troops or people in towns of an enemy's approach. Or it signaled the call to advance or retreat.

### Joshua 6:6–9

the ark of the covenant ... the priests who blew the horns ... and the rear guard: These symbolized God's presence and his leadership during the attack.

### Joshua 6:10–11

- Warriors often shouted in battle to boost their confidence and scare the enemy.
- until the day I tell you: Israel's army marched around Jericho 13 times with only trumpets blowing. Those defending the city became shocked when they finally heard shouting.

### Joshua 6:15

Marching around Jericho seven times on the seventh day again symbolized that this was God's battle.

### Joshua 6:16

Joshua commanded the people, "Shout! For the LORD has given you the city!": This was not meant to make Jericho's walls fall. Instead, Joshua called the Israelites to celebrate the victory that God had already given them.

### Joshua 6:17

- devoted to the LORD for destruction: Joshua reminded his troops that the town and everything in it belonged to God as the firstfruits of their inheritance in the land of Canaan. See Leviticus 27:28–29; 1 Samuel 15:3.
- Rahab: See Joshua 2:12–21.

### Joshua 6:20

After Joshua gave his final instructions, a last blast from the rams' horns marked the final moment.

### Joshua 6:22–23

- The two spies fulfilled Joshua's command and their promise to Rahab. Through the actions of God's people, a pagan household saw that God is trustworthy.
- the house of the prostitute: See study note on 2:1.
- Moving Rahab and her family near the camp of Israel provided security.

### Joshua 6:24

The fire melted and purified the silver, gold, bronze, and iron. These metals had probably been used for the figures of pagan gods. As these images melted, the metals were purified and made fit for dedication to God.

### Joshua 6:24–27

The people of Jericho had already been put to death by the Israelites (6:21). Joshua then destroyed the city and everything in it. As the firstfruits of the battle, all the spoils belonged to God.

### Joshua 6:25

The statement that Rahab lives among the Israelites to this day shows how wide and deep God's grace is. Rahab was not only welcomed into Israel. She later became an ancestor of the Messiah, God's chosen one (see Matthew 1:5).

### Joshua 6:26

Joshua placed a curse on the site because Jericho was the first Canaanite city to resist God's plan to bring Israel into the land. It was also the first city to experience God's judgment on the great wickedness of Canaan. As the firstfruits of Israel's conquest, Jericho belonged to God (Exodus 13:2; 23:19). God later carried out Joshua's curse on the first person who tried to rebuild the city (1 Kings 16:34; compare Joshua 7).

### Joshua 6:27

As the first stage of Israel's conquest of Canaan came to an end, both the Israelites and the Canaanites saw that the Lord was with Joshua, just as he had promised(1:5, 9; compare 4:14). By crossing the Jordan and capturing Jericho, Israel firmly established its presence in the land. This caused the people of Canaan to fear Israel and Israel's God.

### Joshua 7:1

- things devoted to destruction: See Leviticus 27:28–29; 1 Samuel 15:3.
- son of Zerah: Achan was part of an important family. He was a leader or potential leader, so his actions could influence others (Numbers 26:19–20).

### Joshua 7:1–26

After Jericho became part of Israel, Joshua's first military task was to secure a position in the hill country. Conquering Jericho boosted Israel's confidence and left the people of Canaan feeling discouraged and without hope. However, everything depended on Israel's obedience to God. The sin of one man and its consequences show the importance of the command

to destroy Jericho (see "Complete Dedication" Theme Note).

## Joshua 7:1–12.24

This second major section of the book records Joshua's southern and northern campaigns against two coalitions of kings from Canaan. Joshua's victories allowed Israel to settle the hill country from Galilee in the north to the Negev in the south.

## Joshua 7:2

- As he did before the battle for Jericho, Joshua sent some of his men to assess the situation at Ai. This town was about 16 kilometers (10 miles) west of Jericho. It lay at the entrance to a plateau north of Jerusalem called the Plateau of Benjamin. If Israel captured Ai, it would gain control of the hill country.
- Beth-aven, which means "house of iniquity" (place of wrongdoing), was probably an intentional wordplay on the name Bethel, which means "house of God." Later in Israel's history, a pagan shrine stood at this site(1 Kings 12:28–33).

## Joshua 7:3–4

God's gift of victory at Jericho seems to have led to complacency and overconfidence (a false sense of security). Joshua did not even ask God for guidance before he sent a small group of soldiers to Ai.

## Joshua 7:5

- Ai's defenders left through the town gate and attacked Israel's troops directly (see 8:5).
- as far as the quarries: This is a place not known from other sources.

## Joshua 7:6

Israel's leaders tore their clothing and threw dust on their heads, common public gestures of grief or despair in the ancient Near East. By falling face down before the ark of the LORD, Joshua finally admitted that Israel needed God's guidance in the battle against Ai.

## Joshua 7:7

- Joshua spoke to God in anger. This helps explain the sharp tone of God's reply (7:10–15). The battle was lost because of Achan's sin. However, Joshua and Israel's elders had also failed to ask God for guidance (7:3).
- Joshua did not truly believe that Israel should have stayed on the other side of the Jordan River. Instead, he used hyperbole (strong exaggeration) to show that he did not know what to do next.

## Joshua 7:8–9

- Joshua's fears were realistic. All of Canaan had believed that Israel could not be defeated. However, because the small town of Ai defeated Israel, the Canaanites might think this could happen again.
- If God allowed the wicked to destroy his people completely, the nations would no longer have a witness. They would not see that God continues to be involved with his world.
- Your great name: Compare Exodus 32:11–12; Numbers 14:13–19.

## Joshua 7:10–11

Stand up!: God's command was short, severe, and seemed to lack sympathy. For Israel to again have God's favor, Joshua needed to act quickly and be decisive.

## Joshua 7:12

they themselves have been set apart for destruction: Through his individual sin, Achan made the entire nation of Israel liable to destruction.

## Joshua 7:13

Get up and consecrate the people: See study note on 3:5.

## Joshua 7:14

Israel's 12 tribes were descendants of Jacob's sons. A clan represented a smaller unit within the tribes; later, as Israel's allotments in the land were distributed, a clan usually received possession of a town and its surrounding fields, forest, and pastureland. A man's family included his sons and their dependents.

## Joshua 7:15

God had commanded that all stolen goods must be destroyed by fire. Now this command would be carried out, because Achan and everything he owned would be burned with fire. Breaking the covenant of the Lord (the binding agreement between God and his people) was treason (betrayal of loyalty) and a capital offense (a crime punished by death). For example, see Exodus 22:20; Deuteronomy 4:25–27.

## Joshua 7:16–18

Achan may have been identified through the use of the **Urim and** Thummim, a God-given method for casting sacred lots (objects used to seek God's deci-

sion). These items remained in the care of the high priest, probably kept in a bag or pouch (see Exodus 28:30; Numbers 27:21). They may have been two objects of different colors, possibly stones or gems. People asked questions in a way that required a "yes" or "no" answer.

## Joshua 7:19–20

My son: This gentle and compassionate way of speaking shows Joshua as a caring leader. He felt sorrow for this young man, who was trapped by impulsive greed. Although Joshua and Achan both knew that Achan would die for his crime, Joshua urged him to repent. Achan responded with a full confession.

## Joshua 7:21

- They should have burned the cloak with the rest of Jericho's goods. It came from Babylon, showing that long-distance trade was important in the ancient Near East.
- two hundred shekels of silver: Achan took pieces or piles of silver that others would use as money. They did not invent actual coins until the 600s BC.
- I coveted them: See the tenth commandment (Exodus 20:17). Achan's desire for what he saw led him to steal.

## Joshua 7:22

Since the matter was urgent, Joshua sent messengers who ran to the tent to verify what Achan had confessed.

## Joshua 7:24

This careful list of Achan's relatives and possessions, including the stolen items, has the tone of a legal statement. By taking the stolen items, Achan brought guilt on everything connected to him. For this reason, all were included in the judgment against him.

## Joshua 7:25

Stoning was a method of execution sometimes required by God's law (see, for example, Exodus 19:13).

## Joshua 7:26

God had a reason to be angry. God's people must be holy. Lack of respect for what belongs to God shows rebellion. This sin always causes trouble for God's people. Achan's sin caused disaster for Israel. So his severe punishment was fair.

## Joshua 8:1

Do not be afraid or discouraged: God gave Joshua similar encouragement before sending him to Jericho (6:2).

## Joshua 8:1–13

The Israelites made the first attempt to conquer Ai without consulting God. The second attempt was at God's command and direction. Before this attempt, God spoke to Joshua and gave him a strategy. More importantly, after Israel's recent disaster, God offered encouragement and a promise.

## Joshua 8:2

- Unlike other ancient nations that went to war to gain wealth, Israel acted as God's agent to judge the people of Canaan. Their plunder and livestock were secondary.
- The strategy for capturing Ai involved planning an ambush. Joshua followed God's simple instructions effectively.
- behind the town: On its west side (8:12).

## Joshua 8:3

- Set out to attack Ai: This first sentence provides a summary. Details follow in the next paragraphs.
- The Hebrew words translated 30,000 might mean 30 units (see study note on Exodus 12:37) or 30 chieftains (leaders of groups or tribes). As the battle continued, this group waited in hiding for a surprise attack (an ambush). They remained hidden until Joshua called them into action (Joshua 8:18–19).

## Joshua 8:4–9

Joshua told the selected group what to expect from Israel's main army. This special unit would be separated from Joshua's direct command for almost two days. Because of this, they needed to understand clearly what they were supposed to do.

Israel's success in this second attack on Ai depended on exact timing. The group had to rush into the town at the right moment.

## Joshua 8:11–13

The main army marched in front of the town, showing that Joshua did not try to hide them from those defending Ai. The main army approached from the east and camped on Ai's north side by the end of the day. The men in ambush were west of Ai, between Ai and Bethel.

### Joshua 8:14

The king of Ai and all his army were eager to repeat what they thought was their success in the earlier battle. They acted without caution. As Joshua and Israel had already learned, this kind of confidence can lead to danger.

### Joshua 8:15

Joshua and the Israelite army ran away like they did in the first attack (7:4–5).

### Joshua 8:17

- Not a man was left in Ai or Bethel: Soldiers often gained from war by taking trophies from defeated enemies or receiving rewards from their king for each enemy killed.
- The warriors of Bethel likely joined those of Ai because they feared Israel's advance.

### Joshua 8:18–19

Israel succeeded in this second attack on Ai because this time God directed the battle.

### Joshua 8:28

Before its destruction, the town of Ai had a different name that is now unknown. The writer of the book of Joshua always called the town Ai, which means "ruin." This name reflects what the town became after it was destroyed.

### Joshua 8:29

- The public executions of the kings showed that Israel acted as God's agent to judge the leaders and people of Canaan for their evil acts (see also 10:26; 11:10, 12).
- until evening: See Deuteronomy 21:22–23.
- which remains to this day: See Joshua Book Introduction, "Author and Date."

### Joshua 8:30–31

- Archaeologists have recently discovered an altar on Mount Ebal. It was built of uncut stones and was not shaped with iron tools. However, no inscription has been found with the altar (8:32).
- burnt offerings ... peace offerings: These were part of the laws of sacrifice God gave Moses while Israel was at Mount Sinai (Leviticus 1, 3). Moses gave specific commands for this ceremony (see Deuteronomy 11:26–32; 27:1–28:68).

### Joshua 8:32

Joshua carried out what Moses had commanded him to do. He set up stones and covered them with plaster (Deuteronomy 27:2–8). After the plaster hardened, the instructions (Hebrew torah, meaning God's teaching or law) were permanently placed on public display. This took place at the first location where Israel formally worshiped the Lord after entering the land.

Public displays of laws were common in the ancient world. A well-known example is the Code of Hammurabi, which King Hammurabi set up so people could see the laws.

### Joshua 8:33

The town of Shechem is between Mount Gerizim to the south and Mount Ebal to the north. It guarded the passage between these two mountains. Although the ceremony to renew the covenant happened at Shechem, neither the book of Joshua nor Judges mentions that Israel conquered the town. Every Israelite was present. They placed the ark of the covenant in the valley between the two groups. This ceremony was a promise to practice the covenant God made with Israel at Mount Sinai.

### Joshua 8:33–35

This ceremony marked the official claiming of the land, even though major battles against the people of Canaan were still ahead. The sacrifice ceremony and reading of the law of Moses emphasized God's covenant promises and obligations. It also anticipated the eventual possession of all of Canaan.

### Joshua 8:34

the blessings and the curses: See Deuteronomy 27–28.

### Joshua 8:35

- Old Testament religion was not limited to the men of Israel. The entire assembly included women and children.
- the foreigners who lived among them: The Israelites included those who left Egypt with them during the exodus (Exodus 12:38, 48–49). These converts accepted the Lord as their God. They joined Israel after seeing the great things God had done for them.

### Joshua 9:1

- Hittites ... Jebusites: See study note on 3:10.
- The fertile region of lower hills between the highlands of Judah and the southern coastal plain was known as the western foothills.

- Although not all of the coastal plain of the Mediterranean Sea (the Great Sea) was occupied during this period, several important cities did exist. The kings of those small city-states, as far north as Mount Carmel, joined the southern coalition to resist Israel's advances.

## Joshua 9:1–27

Joshua failed to consult God again (9:14; compare 7:2–4). This time it was about an unexpected request. Other ancient Near Eastern stories only describe a leader's successes. However, this author also noted the mistakes of Joshua and Israel's elders. God is the true hero of the story, and the author wanted to emphasize God's achievements.

## Joshua 9:2

Chapter 10 gives a detailed account of these kings and why they joined forces to fight the Israelites.

## Joshua 9:3

The people of Gibeon tried to trick Israel into making a covenant. Gibeon was on a high plain (plateau) north of Jerusalem. It was less than 24 kilometers (15 miles) from Israel's camp at Gilgal (see study note on 7:2).

## Joshua 9:4–6

At that time, traveling long distances was difficult, dirty, and dangerous. To succeed in their trick, the Gibeonites needed their supplies, clothes, and food to appear convincing.

## Joshua 9:7–8

- The name Hivites is known only from the Bible and refers to a non-Semitic ethnic group that lived in various parts of Canaan (see Genesis 34:2; 36:2; Exodus 23:23, 28). Semitic people were ancient groups from the Middle East and North Africa, known for their shared languages (such as Hebrew, Aramaic, or Arabic) and cultural traditions.
- Perhaps you dwell near us: Israel's leaders worried that the visitors were lying. They asked how they could know the visitors did not live nearby. Joshua then asked two direct questions. Still, he could have learned the truth by asking the Lord for guidance (Joshua 9:14).

## Joshua 9:9–10

- In Egypt: See Exodus 7–14.
- kings ... Sihon ... Og: See Numbers 21.

## Joshua 9:11–13

- None of Israel's leaders noticed that the Gibeonites did not answer Joshua's questions. This was because they had become distracted by the false words of praise about God and the idea that a foreign people wanted a treaty.
- If the Israelites spared their lives, the Gibeonites were willing to become Israel's servants and swear to a treaty. This request should have raised suspicions among Israel's leaders. Why would people from a distant land want a treaty of protection?

## Joshua 9:14

Israel's leaders checked the bread to confirm the story of the Gibeonites. But Joshua did not ask the Lord for guidance. This same mistake had caused deaths at Ai. In contrast, Israel won victories at Jericho and Ai by following God's instructions precisely.

## Joshua 9:15

- Israel made a treaty of peace with the Gibeonites. The Israelites were God's subjects, having made a treaty with God at Mount Sinai (see study note on Exodus 20:1–23:33). Israel could not make treaties without God's approval.
- made a treaty of peace with them to let them live (literally made a covenant for their lives): Nations confirmed covenants through a ceremony involving cutting animals in half as sacrifices. The parties of the covenant walked between two halves of animals to show their commitment (compare Genesis 15:9–18). If one party violated the covenant, they risked being cut in half like the sacrifice. Covenants were also written documents, sometimes carved in stone and displayed publicly for everyone to see and remember (see study note on Joshua 8:32).
- In Israel, people swore oaths in the name of the Lord that bound them. violating the oath brought the Lord's judgment for false swearing (Exodus 20:7).

## Joshua 9:16

living among them: When reporting Israel's discovery, the author of Joshua repeated the word the Israelites used to express their suspicion of the Gibeonites (9:7).

## Joshua 9:17

Gibeon, Chephirah, Beeroth, and Kiriath-jearim were on the high flat place (plateau) northwest of Jerusalem and southwest of Bethel and Ai (see study note on 7:2 for more details).

### Joshua 9:18–21

Israel could not violate this treaty, even though the Gibeonites tricked them into making it. Violating a covenant sworn by an oath before the Lord would have shown a lack of respect for God's name and honor (compare Genesis 27:30–38).

### Joshua 9:22

- As Israel's leader, Joshua had the right to gather the Gibeonites for questioning.
- "when in fact you live among us?": By using this phrase, Joshua quietly admitted (acknowledged without saying it directly) that he should not have trusted the Gibeonites without first asking the Lord.

### Joshua 9:23

- under a curse: This means they became servants.
- At that time, the house of my God was the tabernacle. Later, it was the temple in Jerusalem.

### Joshua 9:24–25

The response of the Gibeonites showed their faith in the Lord. They used dishonesty because they believed God would help Israel conquer Canaan.

### Joshua 9:26–27

- This summary ends the account of Joshua's second and final major mistake as a leader.
- to this day: See study note on 4:9.

### Joshua 10:1

Adoni-zedek means "master of righteousness" or "my master is righteous." An earlier king of Jerusalem was named Melchizedek, which means "king of righteousness" or "my king is righteous." He had been a priest of God Most High and a friend of Abraham (Genesis 14:18–20). However, Adoni-zedek was not a friend to Joshua or a believer in the Lord.

### Joshua 10:1–43

Gibeon and its neighboring cities were on a plateau (high flat place) north of Jerusalem (see study note on 7:2). With Gibeon now as an ally with Israel, Israel controlled the plateau and the central hill country near Gibeon. Historically, controlling the plateau often meant controlling the hill country. The kings of Canaan had to conquer Gibeon, or they would fail.

### Joshua 10:2

Gibeon was apparently not a royal city. It may have been under the control of Canaan. They controlled Jerusalem before Gibeon made a covenant with Joshua. Or Gibeon could have been an independent town led by a few leading families.

### Joshua 10:5

In the Old Testament, when it distinguishes between Amorites and Canaanites, the Amorite kings ruled the hill country, while the Canaanites lived in the valleys and the coastal plain.

### Joshua 10:7

Joshua had sworn to rescue Gibeon, so now he set out to do it.

### Joshua 10:8

God once again urged Joshua not to be afraid, assuring him of victory over Israel's enemies (see also 1:9; 8:1).

### Joshua 10:9

- Joshua's army marched all night to travel the 24 kilometers (15 miles) up difficult passes and steep slopes to reach the plateau. When the sun came up, they attacked the Amorite armies from the east. This meant the sun shone bright towards the Amorites as they faced east to fight.
- Israel's covenant required the nation to help Gibeon when it asked for help. However, Joshua acted even faster than the treaty required. By defeating the Canaanite army with a quick attack, Israel gained a strong military advantage.

### Joshua 10:10

It was about 64 kilometers (40 miles) from Gibeon, down the Beth-horon road, then south through the western foothills to Azekah and Makkedah.

### Joshua 10:10–13

Three miracles showed that God alone destroyed the Canaanites. These miracles were:

- supernatural panic,
- a severe hailstorm, and
- a day that lasted longer than normal.

### Joshua 10:12

- Joshua prayed for the day to extend so the Israelites could complete their task. This prevented the Amorites from organizing a new defense against Israel.
- The sun and moon, considered powerful gods in Canaan, were powerless against the LORD.
- Aijalon was a city near the western end of the Beth-horon road.

### Joshua 10:13

- The sun stopped in the middle of the sky: Not all miracles can be fully understood. This includes their purpose, their extent, or how they happened.
- the Book of Jashar: This was one of the ancient sources used by Israel's historians. People in ancient Israel knew this book well. However, it did not survive as a separate document.

### Joshua 10:16

- The five kings: These kings led the southern coalition against God's people.
- Although the location of Makkedah is uncertain, it was in the same district as Lachish in the southern part of the base of the hills in the west (15:39–41). This was about 40 kilometers (25 miles) southwest of Jerusalem. Limestone caves are common in that region.

### Joshua 10:18–19

By blocking the opening of the cave, Joshua reduced the number of guards needed to keep the kings from escaping. This also eliminated danger to the guards and freed more men to pursue the fleeing people.

### Joshua 10:21

- The whole army returned safely: This showed that Israel had few or no losses in this battle. This was a sign of God's presence.
- no one dared: The people of Canaan in the south now knew from personal experience that Israel's powerful God was fighting against them.

### Joshua 10:24

In the ancient Near East, victorious commanders often placed their feet on the necks of defeated kings. This action showed that the kings were fully defeated and under their control.

### Joshua 10:25

Joshua encouraged his men at Makkedah with the same words God used to encourage him before Israel crossed the Jordan River and before the battle of Ai (1:9; 8:1).

### Joshua 10:26–27

Joshua executed the five kings in the same way he dealt with the king of Ai (see note on 8:29).

### Joshua 10:28

He devoted to destruction everyone: See study note on 2:9–10.

### Joshua 10:28–39

Joshua led the Israelites through southern Canaan. They captured several important cities but did not burn them. God had promised that Israel would live in cities they had not built (Deuteronomy 6:10).

### Joshua 10:29–30

Libnah was probably about ten kilometers (six miles) north of Lachish. The exact location of Makkedah is uncertain, so the distance from Libnah is also unknown.

### Joshua 10:31–33

- Lachish was the most important of the six cities captured at this time. It was defended so well that Joshua needed two days to capture it.
- Gezer was about 40 kilometers (25 miles) north of Lachish. Lachish and Gezer might have had a mutual treaty to aid each other.

### Joshua 10:38–39

Settlement in the hill country was sparse. The surrounding villages, which were towns with walls, could not remain independent. They depended on the kingdoms of the dominant cities for protection.

### Joshua 10:40

- Joshua's southern campaign opened the possibility for the southern tribes to settle in the entire region when Israel began the settlement process.
- the foothills: See study note on Deuteronomy 1:7.

### Joshua 10:41

This Goshen was not the region in Egypt's Nile River delta (Genesis 47:27). It was a town in the hill country south of Jerusalem (Joshua 15:51). The area from Goshen as far as Gibeon marks the eastern boundary of Joshua's southern campaign.

### Joshua 10:43

Joshua and his army were free to return to their camp at Gilgal in the Jordan Valley. They then focused on the northern region of Canaan.

## Joshua 11:1–3

- Hazor was on the international trade route and was the largest and most important non-coastal city of Canaan (see 11:10).
- Almost all of northern Canaan joined King Jabin's coalition against Israel. This region stretched from the Mediterranean Sea in the west to the desert in the east. This went from the borders of Phoenicia in the north to the hill country and the Jordan Valley in the south.
- The term Jebusites usually refers to the people of Jerusalem and nearby towns under its control. Men from Jebus might have been soldiers that King Jabin hired.
- Mizpah means "watchtower" or "lookout." Several places had this name. This particular one was the large region on the lower slopes of Mount Hermon. This was the highest peak in the land that God promised Israel.

## Joshua 11:1–16

The detailed accounts of Joshua's campaign in southern Canaan show that the Israelites needed God's help to succeed (chapters 6–10). The same was true for the northern campaign (chapter 11). So those details were not needed here.

## Joshua 11:4

- In the ancient Near East during this period, horses only pulled chariots. Soldiers riding horses (cavalry) and men shooting arrows (archers) who rode horses appeared centuries later.
- Israel probably encountered chariots for the first time in this battle against the northern coalition. Here, the land was flatter than in southern Canaan. Chariots, as the heavy weapons of the battlefield, easily overpowered foot soldiers. Blades were often attached to the axles, and the soldiers drove the chariots at opposing foot soldiers (infantry) to run over them.

## Joshua 11:5

The exact location of Merom is unknown. It was probably in Upper Galilee, a few kilometers west of Hazor.

## Joshua 11:6

- God commanded Joshua not to fear, promising Israel victory even against horses and chariots.
- hamstring their horses and burn up their chariots: God wanted Israel to rely on him instead of weapons and equipment (compare Deuteronomy 17:16; Isaiah 31:1).

## Joshua 11:7

Joshua ... came upon: Jabin might have planned to move from Merom in Upper Galilee to meet Israel on a better battlefield when all his forces were ready. However, Joshua attacked suddenly before Jabin could choose the battlefield.

## Joshua 11:8

The armies of Canaan spread out, moving north and west to Greater Sidon on the Mediterranean coast and east to the Valley of Mizpeh.

## Joshua 11:11

devoting them to destruction: Archaeological excavation confirms that the city of Hazor was destroyed by fire during this period.

## Joshua 11:13

- The cities built on their mounds: In the ancient Near East, it was common practice to rebuild cities on the same sites after they had been destroyed. All the elements that made a city site advantageous remained after a city's destruction. Many cities were rebuilt many times. Each time a city was destroyed, debris piled up. Over time, the city slowly rose higher as this debris accumulated.
- Joshua burned only Hazor in the north, just as he had destroyed Jericho and Ai in the center of the land (6:24; 8:28).

## Joshua 11:15

God commanded Joshua to follow the torah of Moses, or "Book of the Law" (1:7–10). After the two main campaigns to defeat Canaan, the one narrating this story reported that Joshua had obeyed all the commands with loyalty to God.

## Joshua 11:18

The initial victories in the southern and northern campaigns were quick and decisive. However, capturing strong cities took much longer. After Israel crossed the Jordan River, the entire campaign for Canaan possibly lasted five years (see 14:10).

## Joshua 11:19–20

The judgment on Canaan came from God, not Israel. God had shown mercy to the people of Canaan for many generations. However, God decided that "iniquity of the Amorites" now requires that they become set apart for destruction (Genesis 15:16). Therefore, he decided to harden their hearts (to make them stubborn and unwilling to change). God used Israel as

the tool and agent of his judgment. In later centuries, God used other nations to judge Israel and Judah for their sins.

### Joshua 11:21–22

Anakim: See Numbers 13:28, 33.

### Joshua 11:23

- The main theme of the second half of the book of Joshua is dividing the land.
- rest: See study note on 1:13.

### Joshua 12:1

- The Arnon River flows into the Dead Sea halfway down its eastern side, forming the Arnon Valley. Israel started its conquests here (see Numbers 21:13–15, 21–35).
- Mount Hermon is about 40 kilometers (25 miles) north or northeast of the Sea of Galilee.

### Joshua 12:1–24

This chapter summarizes Israel's victories on both sides of the Jordan River. It then moves to Joshua distributing the land of Canaan among the tribes of Israel (chapter 13).

### Joshua 12:2

Sihon controlled the northern Jordan Valley up to the Sea of Galilee, but not northern Gilead (see Numbers 21:24–25; Joshua 12:5).

### Joshua 12:3

- Beth-jeshimoth was where Israel camped in the plains of Moab (Numbers 33:49).
- Moses viewed the promised land from Mount Pisgah (Deuteronomy 34:1).

### Joshua 12:4

- Og king of Bashan: See Numbers 21:33–35.
- the Rephaim: These were native people living on both sides of the Jordan River. Many scholars believe the Rephaim were very tall (see Deuteronomy 3:11).
- Ashtaroth and Edrei: Many rulers of large kingdoms had palaces in multiple cities. Joshua credits only Og with more than one capital. This suggests that his kingdom was larger than others Israel confronted, except for the kingdom of Sihon.

### Joshua 12:6

the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh: See Numbers 32. The author of Joshua reminded the Israelites that their relatives living east of the Jordan River were also part of Israel.

### Joshua 12:7

- Baal-gad was at the western base of Mount Hermon. It marked the northern limit of Joshua's conquests west of the Jordan River.
- The Valley of Lebanon separated the coastal Lebanon mountain range from the non-coastal (inland) Anti-Lebanon range.
- Mount Halak, which leads toward Seir (also known as Edom), marked the southern limit of Joshua's conquests.

### Joshua 12:7–24

Joshua and the Israelites completed the tasks God assigned to them. This summary emphasizes their successes and properly recognizes their loyalty. God gave the Israelites the land he promised to them.

He also finally judged the Canaanites. The list of kings defeated, identified by their city-states, shows God's fulfilled plans. This list was a serious yet joyful recitation for Israel. It reminds the people of God's mighty acts on their behalf and honors his great name.

### Joshua 12:8

Hittites ... Jebusites: See study note on 3:10.

### Joshua 13:1–7

Israel did not conquer all of Canaan during Joshua's lifetime. The areas not conquered, mostly in the valleys and plains, were the places most populated. Several generations passed before Israel was strong enough to control these regions and their people.

### Joshua 13:1–21.45

- As he had promised, God brought Israel into the land. Joshua then focused on dividing the land among Israel's tribes.
- The tribal allowances made the covenant of the Israelites with God real. It showed the fulfillment of God's promise to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. Since God owned the land, giving it to the tribes was a gift. God gave them the land to live in and guided its distribution.
- In these lists of tribal allowances, the author describes some borders in great detail, allowing them

to be mapped. With others, they are less plainly defined.

### Joshua 13:2

The Philistines were part of the Sea Peoples who migrated from the Aegean region a few decades after Israel entered Canaan. They settled along the southwestern Mediterranean coast, west and southwest of Judah. They came from Caphtor or Crete (Deut 2:23; Amos 9:7). • These Geshurites were from a southern territory, not the northern Geshurites (compare Josh 12:5).

### Joshua 13:3

- The stream of Shihor probably marked the traditional border between Canaan and Egypt, dividing the northern Sinai Peninsula.
- The Philistine territory had five main cities. Gaza, Ashdod, and Ashkelon were on the Mediterranean coast. Gath and Ekron were a few miles in from the coast.
- The Philistines replaced the Avvites (Deuteronomy 2:23).

### Joshua 13:4–6

The Sidonians were also known as Phoenicians (see Isaiah 23:11; Obadiah 1:20; Acts 11:19). They lived along the northern coast from north of Mount Carmel to above Gebal (Byblos). They also lived in the Lebanon and Anti-Lebanon mountain ranges. Sidon was the main Phoenician city when Israel entered Canaan.

### Joshua 13:6–7

Israel had not yet conquered the lands mentioned. However, God instructed Joshua to demonstrate his faith by assigning them to the tribes for the future, when Israel would capture them.

### Joshua 13:8–14

Half the tribe of Manasseh and the tribes of Reuben and Gad asked Moses for land on the east side of the Jordan. This land was once the kingdoms of Sihon and Og (Numbers 21:21–35; 32:1–42). In return, they helped the rest of Israel claim their land west of the Jordan (Joshua 1:12–18; 4:12–13). Here, the author confirmed their ownership of these lands.

### Joshua 13:14

The tribe of Levi did not receive its own tribal land (land passed down to a tribe as an inheritance). Instead, Levitical cities were spread throughout the territories of the other tribes (see Deuteronomy 18:1–8; Joshua 21).

### Joshua 13:15–23

Reuben, Jacob's first son by Leah, lost his inheritance because he slept with his father's concubine (Genesis 29:32; 35:22). As a result, his tribe's inheritance was not very important. Although the tribe received productive land, it was hard to defend from nearby nations. Eventually, the tribe of Reuben lost the southern part to Moab.

### Joshua 13:21

The leaders of Midian were likely kings or sheiks (local rulers of small city-states) south of Sihon's kingdom (Numbers 31:8). The Midianites lived a nomadic life (they moved from place to place and did not stay in one permanent home). They depended mainly on sheep and goats for their living.

### Joshua 13:22

Balaam, son of Beor: He created a plan to lead Israel into the worship of false gods (idolatry) through sexual sin (Numbers 31:16). God had forbidden Balaam from cursing Israel (Numbers 22–25).

### Joshua 13:24–28

Gad was Jacob's seventh son, born to Zilpah, Leah's servant. Like Gad's minor role in his family, the tribe of Gad had a minor role in Israel.

### Joshua 13:29–33

Manasseh was Joseph's elder son. Jacob gave Joseph's sons each a full inheritance, thus giving Joseph a double portion of the birthright (see 14:4).

### Joshua 13:30–31

Jair was a great-grandson of Manasseh (1 Chronicles 2:21–22). Machir was one of Manasseh's sons. It is uncertain if the land given to these tribes in north Gilead was different from the land that the tribe of Gad received there.

### Joshua 14:1

Eleazar, Joshua, and the leaders of the tribes oversaw the distribution of the land to ensure that the process was honest and just.

## Joshua 14:1–19.51

- The allotment of land to the tribes on the west side of the Jordan describes what God intended for each tribe to possess.
- The one narrating the story begins this section with Caleb receiving land and ends with Joshua receiving land (14:6–15; 19:49–51). Only Caleb and Joshua had shown faith in God that Israel could conquer the land (Numbers 13:30; 14:6–9).

## Joshua 14:2

assigned by lot: See study note on 7:16–18.

## Joshua 14:4

Joseph, the older son of the patriarch Jacob's favorite wife Rachel, received twice as much land through his sons Manasseh and Ephraim (see study note on Genesis 48:5–7). Since the Levites did not get their own land allowance, the total number of tribes with land remained at 12 (Joshua 13:14).

## Joshua 14:6

- The Kenizzite people were not originally Israelites (Genesis 15:19). How they became connected to Judah is unknown.
- about you and me: Only Caleb and Joshua remained true to God when they first had the chance to enter the land. Therefore, God promised them that they would inherit it (Numbers 14:24).

## Joshua 14:9

Moses swore: See Numbers 14:24.

## Joshua 14:11

Caleb believed he was as strong at 85 years old as he was at 40. He still felt ready to travel and fight, continuing both ordinary and extraordinary activities.

## Joshua 14:12

Israel stayed away from Canaan 45 years earlier because they feared those descended from Anak (Anakim). These were tall, strong people living in the hills of Judah (Numbers 13:32–33).

## Joshua 14:15

rest from war: See study note on 1:13.

## Joshua 15:1–63

The description of Judah's allotment of tribes is more detailed than that of the other tribes. The failures of Judah's older brothers positioned him to lead (Genesis 34:25–31; 35:22). As a result, the tribe of Judah received a central location among the tribes, guaranteeing its leadership in the nation (Genesis 49:8–12; Deuteronomy 33:7).

## Joshua 15:2–4

Judah's southern boundary extended well into the desert of the Negev, which had little if any settled population throughout the Old Testament period.

## Joshua 15:5–11

Although Judah's northern boundary is described in great detail, some sections of this border cannot be determined with certainty.

## Joshua 15:7

- This Debir was a different town from the Debir that was also known as Kiriath-sepher in 15:15.
- This Gilgal was different from the Gilgal where the Israelites established their camp earlier (4:19).

## Joshua 15:8

The Valley of Ben-Hinnom marked Judah's northern border. Jerusalem was along a narrow hilltop going north from the valley's lower end, within Benjamin's territory. Neither tribe controlled Jerusalem, so when David captured it, it became the royal city of his family line of kings instead of just another city of a tribe.

## Joshua 15:9

The spring at the Waters of Nephtoah might refer to Egyptian Pharaoh Merneptah from the late 1200s BC. An Egyptian papyrus scroll mentions the "wells of Merneptah" on the mountain ridges of Canaan.

## Joshua 15:12

These were Judah's boundaries when the settlement process started. Later, the tribes of Simeon and Dan received land from Judah's southern and western territories. Within a few decades, the Philistines arrived from the Greek islands and settled the entire southern coastal plain given to Judah (see study note on 13:2).

## Joshua 15:16

Compare 1 Samuel 17:25; 18:27.

## Joshua 15:17

Othniel, Caleb's nephew, became the first judge of Israel (Judges 3:9–11).

## Joshua 15:18–19

- What do you desire?: The town that Othniel conquered had no water source. Negev means "dry land."
- The upper and lower springs were close together, but too far from Debir to naturally belong to it. So, Acsah asked for the rights to the water.

## Joshua 15:20–63

We cannot identify all of these locations with certainty. Many are unknown except for their mention in this and other lists. Some are briefly mentioned in other texts.

## Joshua 15:21

- in the Negev (see study note on 1:4): The Hebrew word negeb can refer either to the general direction ("south") or the desert region named "Negev."
- The location of Eder is otherwise unknown. Some propose translating this word as "Arad" because Arad should be about here in the list and was too important to have been left out. This translation would simply reverse two Hebrew letters that are very similar in shape.

## Joshua 15:33

From the perspective of the highlanders of the Judean hill country, the lower hills between them and the coastal plain were the western foothills. These hills were separated geologically from the hill country by a series of north–south valleys. In this list, the western foothills are divided into four districts.

## Joshua 15:45–47

The fourth district of the western foothills included most of the territory soon to be occupied by the Philistines. The tribe of Judah held it only briefly.

## Joshua 15:48

The hill country was in the central highlands of Judah from Jerusalem in the north to just past Debir in the south (15:15). It was divided into five districts.

## Joshua 15:56

This Jezreel in Judah was not the northern Jezreel. This city was the hometown of Ahinoam, David's wife and the mother of his eldest son, Amnon (2 Samuel 3:2).

## Joshua 15:59

After this verse, the Greek Old Testament lists another district with 11 cities. These cities are:

- Tekoa,
- Ephrathah (that is, Bethlehem),
- Phagor,
- Etam,
- Kulon,
- Tatam,
- Saris,
- Karem,
- Gallim,
- Bether, and
- Manoch.

Each city also had surrounding villages.

Including this district explains why Bethlehem appears in the list. Without this district, Bethlehem would be missing, which would be unexpected. It is possible that an early copyist of the Hebrew text accidentally left out this twelfth district.

## Joshua 15:61

The wilderness of Judea included the eastern slopes of the central mountain highlands and extended to the western shore of the Dead Sea; three of its six towns were on or near that shoreline.

## Joshua 15:63

- Joshua assigned Jerusalem to the tribe of Benjamin (18:28). But they did not conquer it during Joshua's time.
- to this day: The presence of the Jebusites later caused trouble for Judah (Judges 1:21).

## Joshua 16:1

The tribe of Benjamin received Jericho as their territory (18:21).

## Joshua 16:1–17.18

Joseph had two sons, Manasseh and Ephraim (Genesis 41:50–52). Half of those descended from Manasseh received their inheritance east of the Jordan River. The tribe of Ephraim and the rest of Manasseh's tribe now received their land. This made the total number of land portions twelve, fulfilling Jacob's blessing to Joseph (Genesis 49:22–26). Like Judah in the south, Joseph's tribes led from their central position in the north.

## Joshua 16:3

- Ephraim's border went from Lower Beth-horon to upper Beth-horon. This gave this tribe control of one of the two main roads to Jerusalem from the west (see 16:5).

- Gezer was a large and important town of Canaan at the meeting point of the coastal plain and the hill country. This apparently did not come into Israel's possession until the time of King Solomon (see Judges 1:29; 1 Kings 9:16).

## Joshua 16:5–8

This description of Ephraim's northern boundary with Manasseh is general and incomplete. Because Shechem belonged to Manasseh, the border between the two tribes ran south of that town.

## Joshua 17:1

See 13:29–33 and study note.

## Joshua 17:3–6

In ancient Israel, inheritance usually passed from a father to his sons. Without sons, a man's name could pass into oblivion. However, Zelophehad's daughters had petitioned Moses, Moses had inquired of God, and God had ruled that they should inherit their father's portion (see Numbers 27:1–11). God's ruling established a general principle, declaring that no family would be excluded from a portion of God's material blessings.

## Joshua 17:7

Asher was north-northwest of Manasseh, across the Jezreel Valley.

## Joshua 17:7–13

As with the tribe of Ephraim, Manasseh's territory was defined by a general description of its borders.

## Joshua 17:8–10

This general description of Manasseh's southern border with the land given to the tribe of Ephraim provides more detail than the description of Ephraim's northern border in 16:8.

## Joshua 17:11–13

All the towns mentioned here except Endor were important, but the military strength of the Canaanites prevented the tribe of Manasseh from inhabiting them for a time.

## Joshua 17:13

Throughout the period of the judges and beyond, the Israelites gradually grew stronger and the Canaanite people weaker. After the time of Joshua, the Israelites forced the Canaanites to work as slaves. Eventually, the Canaanites became part of the nation of Israel, contributing to Israel worshiping their false gods. This idolatry ultimately led to the Israelites losing the land.

## Joshua 17:14

Joshua 16:1–4 describes Joseph's portion. Those descended from Ephraim and Manasseh received portions. When combined, these were larger than any other tribe's allotment.

## Joshua 17:15

- The Perizzites lived in Canaan when Israel's conquest started.
- Rephaim: See study note on 12:4; see also Deuteronomy 2:10–11, 20–21; 3:11.

## Joshua 17:16

- As a result of the Canaanites' iron chariots, Ephraim and Manasseh were restricted to the hill country in the early part of the settlement period (see study note on 11:4).
- the Valley of Jezreel: This was a break in the hill country, separating Lower Galilee in the north from Manasseh's hill country in the south. The Canaanites living in and near this valley and the valley of Beth-shan limited Manasseh's and likely Ephraim's expansion. Most towns named in 17:11 were at the edges of these valleys.

## Joshua 17:17–18

Rather than rebuking the people for their fear, Joshua repeated his instructions to clear forest land for settlement. He promised that the tribes of Ephraim and Manasseh would eventually drive out the Canaanites. This promise gave them hope. It also helped them grow in faith and overcome their fear.

Much of the hill country was covered with forests, and only a few Canaanites lived there. If Ephraim and Manasseh had settled only on land that was already cleared, they would have had little room to grow. Around this time, people began to use iron tools, including iron axe heads. With these tools, the tribes could cut down the forests and prepare new land for settlement.

Joshua may have set an example by doing this himself. He settled at Timnath-serah, which was in a forested area of the hill country of Ephraim (19:50).

### Joshua 18:1

Israel camped at Gilgal in the Jordan Valley (14:6). Shiloh was about 32 kilometers (20 miles) north of Jerusalem, in the hills of Ephraim. By placing the Tent of Meeting there, Joshua made Shiloh the religious and political center of Israel. The Tent of Meeting remained at Shiloh until the Philistines captured the ark of God (1 Samuel 4:10–11).

### Joshua 18:4

- The three selected representatives from each tribe came from the seven tribes that had not yet received their allotments.
- map it out: Israel was not entirely an oral society. If an event or record was important enough to be remembered over time, leaders ordered that it be written down.

### Joshua 18:5

The remaining land was divided into seven sections, one for each tribe not yet assigned its territory.

### Joshua 18:6

Joshua cast sacred lots in public to prevent envy or suspicion among the people (see also study note on 7:16–18).

### Joshua 18:7

- The Levites: See chapter 21.
- Gad ... Manasseh: See 13:15–33.

### Joshua 18:9

- The Canaanites in the hill country feared Israel. They allowed 21 men to walk through these territories and return safely (18:4).
- The written record was likely a scroll. This scroll might have been the original source for the descriptions of the tribal allotments in chapters 18–19.

### Joshua 18:11

Benjamin was Jacob's twelfth and last son. He was the second son of Rachel, Jacob's favorite wife. Those descended from him received a small but important piece of land between Judah and Joseph.

### Joshua 18:21–28

Judah's land had 11 or 12 districts (see study note on 15:59). The tribe of Benjamin had 2, with a total of 26 towns. However, Benjamin's location between the lands of Judah and Joseph gave it much greater economic and military importance than its size would suggest.

### Joshua 18:28

- Jerusalem: See study note on 15:8.
- Kiriath: The Kiriath-jearim mentioned in 18:14 was part of Judah. belonged to Judah. Another town with the same name may have existed, but we do not know anything else about it.

### Joshua 19:1

Simeon, the second son of Jacob and Leah, was older than Judah. However, he lost a leading role because of his violent actions against Shechem (Genesis 34:25–26). The tribal inheritance of his descendants reflected this. Their land came from Judah's territory, on the southern edge of the Negev. This land was dry and far from centers of influence and power.

### Joshua 19:2–9

Some of the towns given to the tribe of Simeon were also part of Judah's land. This happened because Judah's territory was too large for them (compare 17:14–18). Most of Simeon's territory became part of Judah before the end of the Old Testament period.

### Joshua 19:10–16

The tribe of Zebulun received land partly in the Jezreel Valley and partly in the hills of Lower Galilee.

### Joshua 19:10–23

The tribes of Zebulun and Issachar had lands in a strategic location. The main international trade route from Egypt to Mesopotamia passed through their territories. When Israel was strong, this location brought wealth. However, when Israel was weak, these tribes became exposed to attacks from Egyptian armies and Mesopotamian powers fighting for control of the ancient Near East.

### Joshua 19:10–48

The five small remaining tribes received land on the edges of Israelite territory and had little influence on the nation.

### Joshua 19:13

Gath-hepher was the hometown of the prophet Jonah (2 Kings 14:25).

### Joshua 19:15

- This Bethlehem was not in Judah, where King David and Jesus were born.
- More than 12 towns are listed. Some apparently were not part of Zebulun but were on its borders.

### Joshua 19:16

Zebulun was the smallest tribe in terms of both the number of towns and the size of its territory. However, the New Testament village of Nazareth, where Jesus grew up, was in Zebulun's territory (Matthew 2:19–23; 4:13–16).

### Joshua 19:17–23

The land given to the tribe of Issachar included much of the fertile Jezreel Valley. During Old Testament times, much of this valley was swampy land, surrounded by prosperous and important cities. This area was a center of Canaanite power, so this small tribe had trouble gaining control of the land at first.

### Joshua 19:24–31

The land given to the tribe of Asher included the Plain of Acco on the Mediterranean coast and western Galilee. To the southwest, Asher extended to Mount Carmel, sharing a short border with the land given to the tribe of Manasseh. To the north, the Phoenician cities of Tyre and Sidon restricted Asher's growth.

### Joshua 19:30

twenty-two cities: This did not include Tyre and Sidon, which the nation of Israel never controlled.

### Joshua 19:32–39

The tribe of Naphtali occupied eastern Galilee and overlooked the Sea of Galilee. Because a branch of an international trade route from Egypt to Mesopotamia ran through the territory of Naphtali, this tribe enjoyed periods of prosperity when Israel's kings were strong. The city of Hazor was within Naphtali's territory, guarding a section of that route. Naphtali is mentioned in Matthew 4:13–16 in connection with the ministry of Jesus in Galilee.

### Joshua 19:40–48

The original allotment given to the tribe of Dan lay west of Judah and southwest of Ephraim's main territory, between Judah and Philistia.

### Joshua 19:43

About fifty years after Israel entered Canaan under Joshua, the Philistines moved into the southern coastal plain and took over the cities of Timnah and Ekron (Judges 14:1–2; 1 Samuel 5:1–10). The Philistines were part of the Sea Peoples, who may have left the Greek mainland and islands because of a northern invasion. The Sea Peoples also invaded and destroyed the Hittite Empire north of Israel. Some scholars believe that Homer's Iliad reflects this movement.

### Joshua 19:47

The tribe of Dan (the Danites) struggled to take their land because of the Philistines. Later, some Danites moved north to Laish (see Judges 18). They renamed it Dan, on the northern border of Israel's territory.

### Joshua 19:49–50

The land given to Joshua ends the section about dividing land among the tribes of Israel (see study note on 14:1–19:51).

### Joshua 19:51

After Joshua received his inheritance, the land division was complete. Joshua served God and led Israel in loyalty for many years. God was gracious to Joshua.

### Joshua 20:1–6

These verses review the law about cities of refuge (see also Numbers 35:6–34).

### Joshua 20:1–21.45

Before they fully divided the land, Joshua had to establish six cities of refuge and assign cities in which the Levites would live.

### Joshua 20:3

The relatives of a victim murdered or killed unintentionally or accidentally were responsible for seeking revenge. If the avenger (Hebrew go'el) found the person who killed outside a city of refuge, he could kill him without suffering punishment.

### Joshua 20:7–9

Joshua chose six cities of refuge. Three were on the east side of the Jordan River and three were on the west side. From anywhere in the land, people could reach one of these well-known Levitical cities within two days of travel.

### Joshua 20:9

Israel's treatment of foreigners was an important advance in human relations. The law required that foreign residents in Israel receive the same justice as native Israelites (see Exodus 22:21; Leviticus 19:33–34; 24:22; Numbers 15:15–16).

### Joshua 21:1–8

Israel's leaders assigned towns to the tribe of Levi by casting lots (see study note on 7:16–18).

### Joshua 21:2–3

The Lord commanded Moses, as recorded in Numbers 35:1–7. One priestly duty was to teach God's law to Israel (see study note on 1:8). The Levites could do this better by living in all the areas of the tribes.

### Joshua 21:4

Those descended from Aaron the priest became Israel's priests. They received cities by lot. The towns of the priests were amongst tribes near Jerusalem, where the temple was later built.

### Joshua 21:5

The rest of the descendants of Kohath received cities in the central hill country, north of Jerusalem.

### Joshua 21:6

The clan of Gershon received cities among the four northernmost tribes in Israel.

### Joshua 21:7

The clan of Merari did not stay together as other Levitical clans did.

### Joshua 21:8

The pasturelands were areas for feeding flocks or cattle around the cities. The repeated use of this word in the list made the land allowance seem like a legal record (21:8–42). It guaranteed the Levites had access to lands right next to each city given to the Levites (Numbers 35:4–5).

### Joshua 21:9–42

The descendants of Aaron received thirteen cities, the rest of the Kohathite clan received ten, the descendants of Gershon received thirteen, and the Merari clan received twelve. There were a total of forty-eight Levitical cities. Each tribe had four Levitical cities, except Judah had eight, Simeon had one, and Naphtali had three. Six of the Levitical cities were also cities of refuge (20:7–8).

### Joshua 21:45

God had made Israel many good promises, and not one had failed. He kept his promise to give Israel possession of the land and to save them from their surrounding enemies.

### Joshua 22:1–34

Joshua first said goodbye to the tribes east of the Jordan River when he sent them home. As usual, he urged them to remain loyal to God.

### Joshua 22:1–24.33

Israel completed the conquest and allotment of the land, but much of the hard work of actually settling it still lay ahead. However, all that remained for Joshua in his role as leader of Israel was to say goodbye.

### Joshua 22:2–3

Joshua commended the eastern tribes for their faithful obedience and the fulfillment of their promise to help the rest of Israel settle Canaan (see 1:12–18; Numbers 32:1–32).

### Joshua 22:4–6

Joshua's words remind us of God's words to him at the start of the conquest (1:1–9). To live in the land, Israel had to be true to God by carefully obeying all the commands and instructions given to Moses.

### Joshua 22:5

all your heart and with all your soul: See Deuteronomy 6:5.

### Joshua 22:7

Moses had given: The author takes great care to emphasize that the tribes east of the Jordan were part of Israel.

### Joshua 22:8

- The great wealth was the share of the trophies of war of these tribes from the cities Israel had captured.
- Divide with your brothers: While most of the fighting men helped the rest of Israel, some men remained to protect the women, children, and herds.

### Joshua 22:10

Geliloth: It is reasonable to assume that Geliloth and the altar were on the west side of the Jordan River.

### Joshua 22:10–20

Reuben, Gad, and the half-tribe of Manasseh built their own altar, which caused a conflict with the rest of Israel.

### Joshua 22:11

The Israelites (literally the sons of Israel): This refers to those given land west of the Jordan River, in Canaan. They already called themselves Israel, excluding the tribes east of the Jordan River.

### Joshua 22:12

The western tribes prepared for war because they believed the altar violated the rules in Leviticus 17:8–9 and Deuteronomy 13:12–15.

### Joshua 22:13–14

- Ten chiefs: See Deuteronomy 13:14.
- The ten tribes west of the Jordan River included Ephraim and the western half of Manasseh, but not the tribe of Levi.

### Joshua 22:15

The group of ten chiefs crossed the Jordan River to meet the leaders of the eastern tribes in Gilead, likely in southern Gad.

### Joshua 22:15–20

The direct statements and questions of the group of ten chiefs guaranteed that God's anger did not fall on the nation because of rebellion, like Achan's incident or the event at Peor (7:1–15; Numbers 25).

### Joshua 22:16

- The group of ten chiefs delivered the message that the ten tribes agreed upon at Shiloh.
- This is what the whole congregation of the LORD says: The formula including the first two words in the Hebrew text, "This is what ... says," was a common way to start a messenger's report (for example, Ezra 1:2; Isaiah 28:16).

### Joshua 22:17

The sin at Peor was the rebellion in Moab by Israel in worshiping false gods. This happened just before entering the promised land (Numbers 25). Phinehas, now the leader of this group of chiefs, had acted to save Israel from complete destruction at that time. He did not want to see any part of Israel rebel against God again.

### Joshua 22:19

- Becoming ceremonially unclean did not always result from rebellion or a moral mistake. But it did stop people or groups from joining regular worship activities, including offering sacrifices. If the eastern tribes had made the land ceremonially unclean, the Israelites could not offer sacrifices to the Lord there. This concern gives evidence that the eastern tribes had built their altar on the western bank of the Jordan River.
- The land west of the Jordan River was the LORD's possession. The group of chiefs from the western tribes made a generous offer by inviting the eastern tribes to share their land. This showed their commitment to national unity and loyalty to God.

### Joshua 22:20

Achan: See chapter 7. The group of chiefs from the western tribes feared that Achan's sin and its consequences might happen again.

### Joshua 22:21–34

The eastern tribes explained why they acted as they did.

### Joshua 22:22

The LORD ... is God!: Repeating this dramatic statement shows how surprised the eastern tribes were when accused of rebellion.

### Joshua 22:23

- The eastern tribes swore by the name of the LORD that they were not guilty.
- The instructions for sacrificing required burnt offerings, grain offerings, or peace offerings (Leviticus 1–3). At this time, Israel worshiped at the tabernacle in Shiloh. Offering sacrifices anywhere other than the central holy place violated God's covenant.

### Joshua 22:24–29

The eastern tribes worried they might become excluded from Israel later because the Jordan River separated them from the western tribes.

### Joshua 22:27

The altar near the Jordan River bank would serve as a witness for future generations that the eastern tribes were also part of Israel.

### Joshua 22:28

This altar was a copy, intended to be seen, not used.

### Joshua 22:31

you have delivered: In his reply to the eastern tribes, Phinehas used language similar to God's words when Phinehas turned God's anger from Israel at Peor (Numbers 25:11).

### Joshua 22:33

Both the eastern and western tribes felt relieved that they avoided the crisis. They joyfully praised God to renew their commitment to national unity and loyalty to him.

### Joshua 22:34

Witness: Hebrew texts that include this word interpret the last statement as an explanation of the name. Texts that do not include the word understand the last quotation to be the name of the altar.

### Joshua 23:1–11

Joshua strongly encouraged Israel's leaders to be faithful.

### Joshua 23:2–3

The leaders of Israel witnessed God's actions for them and against their enemies. During the lives of these leaders who lived longer than Joshua, Israel remained faithful to God (Judges 2:7).

### Joshua 23:4–5

The Israelites had not yet conquered some of the land Joshua assigned to the tribes. Israel took possession of the land slowly for several reasons:

- There was an ecological reason. God said that the people should not drive out all the inhabitants at once, so that wild animals would not increase too quickly (see Exodus 23:29–30).
- There was also a military reason. Israel did not yet have enough strength or technology to defeat some groups, especially those with iron chariots (see Judges 1:19).
- There was also a theological reason. God allowed some Canaanite groups to remain in the land to test Israel's faithfulness and obedience (see Judges 2:20–3:4).

However, Israel did not remain faithful. Instead of driving out the remaining Canaanites, the Israelites lived among them and adopted some of their practices. This brought strong temptations that led Israel away from loyalty to the Lord. Joshua warned the people that this danger was real and serious (see Joshua 23:15–16).

### Joshua 23:6

Before Israel crossed the Jordan River to take the land of Canaan, Joshua had followed one guiding principle. He was careful to obey everything that Moses had written and not turn away from it.

Now, as Joshua prepared to die, he passed these same instructions on to the leaders who would come after him. He urged them to lead Israel by obeying God's instruction with the same care and faithfulness.

### Joshua 23:7

You must not call on ... swear by them... serve ... bow down to them: These four actions show increasing involvement in worship of false gods.

### Joshua 23:8

To hold fast or commit to God would weaken the temptation to follow false gods. The same verb describes a man "united to his wife" (Genesis 2:24). It also describes how Ruth "clung" to Naomi (Ruth 1:14).

### Joshua 23:9

Examples of strong and powerful enemies included the Anakim, a group of very tall warriors, and the city of Hazor, which was a major military center in northern Canaan (11:10, 21–22).

### Joshua 23:10

God fights for you: God fought for the Israelites earlier (for example, 10:11–14). He would keep fighting for them in the future.

### Joshua 23:11

watch yourselves carefully, that you love: In Scripture, love is an act of the will and a matter of intention. Feelings and attraction may follow, but they are not the core of love.

Because love is chosen, God can command people to love. However, love cannot be forced or controlled by pressure or fear.

### Joshua 23:12

Joshua warned God's people not to marry their neighbors who worshiped many gods. Such close relationships could lead the Israelites to be unfaithful to God (Deuteronomy 7:3–4). However, people from Canaan who wanted to worship the Lord and join God's people were welcome (Joshua 6:25; Ruth 4:10). Race,

language, and ethnic group did not affect God's rule against marrying non-Israelites. It was a matter of remaining loyal to the Lord (see 2 Corinthians 6:14–15).

### Joshua 23:12–16

Apostasy (turning away from the true God) leads to destruction.

Because God is holy, Joshua could speak with confidence about God's promises and about the good land God had given the people. God does not change in his holy character, even when his people change.

The rebellion of God's people does not harm God's holiness. However, rebellion does bring destruction on those who choose it.

### Joshua 23:13

God will no longer drive out: If Israel associated with the remaining people of Canaan, God would allow the people of Canaan to remain in the land. God ultimately gives people what they desire.

### Joshua 23:15–16

God had blessed the Israelites, but he would also judge them if they turned away from him. Joshua's warning about apostasy was prophetic.

Israel did turn away from the Lord. As a result, God did not drive out the remaining Canaanites (Judges 2:20–23).

### Joshua 24:1

Shechem was where Israel first confirmed the covenant soon after entering Canaan (see 8:30–35 and corresponding study notes).

### Joshua 24:1–13

Joshua reminded the people of the many ways God had shown grace to Israel throughout their history.

### Joshua 24:1–27

In both its form and its content, this covenant statement is similar to an ancient Near Eastern suzerain–vassal treaty (a treaty between a powerful ruler and a weaker people). The suzerain protects them and provides benefits, and in return, the weaker people (the vassal) owe loyalty and obedience.

The covenant begins with a preamble, which identifies the speaker (24:2). It then includes a historical prologue. This section recounts the suzerain's gracious acts, describing what God had done for the people in the past (24:3–13).

Next, the covenant lists the stipulations, or required obligations, that the people must follow (24:14–15). It also warns of curses and promises blessings, depending on whether the people obey or disobey (24:19–20).

Finally, the passage notes where the covenant text was recorded so it could be read again in the future (implied in 24:26). It also names witnesses who confirmed the covenant agreement (24:22, 27). See also study note on Exodus 20:1–23:33.

### Joshua 24:2

Terah: See Genesis 11:27–32.

### Joshua 24:3

- Abraham lived at Haran in Mesopotamia beyond the Euphrates with his father Terah (Genesis 11:31–32).
- God led him through ... Canaan: See Genesis 12:1–9.

### Joshua 24:3–13

"I took ... I gave ... I sent ... I brought": Joshua repeated God's words. This reminded the Israelites to remain loyal to God. Israel's faith always began with God's actions.

### Joshua 24:4

- Jacob and Esau: See Genesis 25:19–26.
- Mount Seir was in the center of Edom, where those who descended from Esau lived (Genesis 36:8–9).

### Joshua 24:5–7

The exodus from Egypt, which reached its climax when the Israelites crossed the Red Sea, was the central act of salvation in Israel's history. Many psalms, several later prophets, and a number of New Testament writers all pointed back to this event and celebrated its importance.

### Joshua 24:6

Red Sea: See study note on Exodus 13:18.

### Joshua 24:7

Even though the older Israelites present here had been children at the time of the exodus, they had seen the events with their very own eyes.

### Joshua 24:8

Amorites ... their land: See Numbers 21:21–35.

### Joshua 24:9–10

See Numbers 22–25 and 31:1–54.

### Joshua 24:11

See study note on 3:10.

### Joshua 24:12

Israel's victories did not come from their swords, bows, or any military strength. God alone brought about their success.

### Joshua 24:13

land ... cities ... and vineyards and olive groves: The Israelites received wealth they had not earned or created.

### Joshua 24:14

cast aside the gods: Israel had not fully turned away from the old polytheistic traditions (the worship of many gods) of Mesopotamia, east of the Euphrates River. While living in Egypt, some Israelites had even added other gods to the ones they already worshiped.

### Joshua 24:15

Joshua used his influential leadership and achievements to support his declaration to serve the Lord.

### Joshua 24:16

The people responded strongly, showing their determination to follow Joshua's leadership in obeying the Lord.

### Joshua 24:16–18

The people realized that God saved them, protected them, and drove out the Amorites.

### Joshua 24:19

- He is a holy God: See "God's Absolute Holiness" Theme Note.
- He is a jealous God: He created every human to have a relationship with him.

### Joshua 24:19–24

Joshua challenged the Israelites from another perspective to show how serious their commitment needed to be. He wanted to make sure they were not responding only out of excitement in the moment.

### Joshua 24:22

You are witnesses against yourselves: Joshua commanded the people to repeat their declaration as a legal confirmation and commitment. This made them witnesses to their own decision.

### Joshua 24:23

Some Israelites had continued to worship idols since they left Egypt and after experiencing 40 years of God's love and power. Joshua directed them to destroy the idols and turn their hearts to the Lord to serve him alone.

### Joshua 24:25

made a covenant: This phrase is literally "cut a covenant." It refers to an ancient practice in which people made a binding agreement by cutting animals as part of a formal ceremony. This act showed how serious and lasting the agreement was (see study note on 9:15).

### Joshua 24:26

- the Book of the Law: This book was a scroll that contained the writings of Moses (see study note on 1:8). It was probably taken to Shiloh and stored with other documents that were important for the nation.
- the large stone: This stone was probably a stela (a standing stone monument). Joshua may have had words carved into it as a memorial inscription to mark the covenant event.

### Joshua 24:27

it has heard all the words: See study note on 22:27.

### Joshua 24:29

Joshua's ancestor Joseph also lived to be 110 years old. Ancient Egyptians considered this the ideal length of life.

### Joshua 24:29–33

The tombs of a respected ancestor and two honored leaders served as a final sign that Canaan truly belonged to Israel. Even so, much work still remained. The people would need to stay alert, and at times they would still need to fight.

### Joshua 24:30

Timnath-serah: See 19:49–51.

### Joshua 24:31

Joshua's leadership left a lasting impact. Israel remained faithful to God during his lifetime and during the lives of the elders who lived longer than he did.

## Joshua 24:32

- The people of Israel took the bones of Joseph from Egypt to Canaan to honor his wish to be buried in the land God promised them (Genesis 50:25; Exodus 13:19).
- Shechem was part of the land given to those descended from Joseph, located between Ephraim and Manasseh. Jacob bought this land centuries earlier for 100 pieces of silver.

## Joshua 24:33

- Eleazar, the high priest, stood beside Joshua while they divided the land among the tribes of Israel.
- They buried Joshua, Joseph, and Eleazar in Ephraim, in the central part of the newly conquered land. Their burial was a final sign that God fulfilled his promise to give Israel the land.